

Wake Forest - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Bowl-line Power 4 team with a defense-first floor and a wide offensive range
Preseason consensus	AP Unranked (0 votes) · ACC media 13th (1,103 points) · SP+ No. 57
Returning production	53% (No. 63) overall · Off. 45% (No. 99) · Def. 61% (No. 36)
Primer power rating	+3.5 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	6.1 wins · likely 6-6
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ Worse and more volatile despite a plausible QB upgrade
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: Wake Forest should try to raise a poor 2025 offensive efficiency floor by pairing QB Gio Lopez's direct familiarity with Rob Ezell's system with a broad portal rebuild at RB, WR and OL, while the defense remains the more trustworthy side behind DL Langston Hardy and a returning front-seven core.

Bottom line: Wake Forest has enough quarterback/system fit and defensive continuity to stay near bowl eligibility, but a 9-4 repeat would require major portal hits on offense and in the secondary because the underlying model, returning production and preseason consensus all point to a substantial step back.

Beats expectations if: QB Gio Lopez immediately translates Ezell familiarity into better early-down efficiency, the transfer-heavy OL protects well enough to unlock the receiving rotation, and DL Langston Hardy/LB Aiden Hall keep the defense near its 2025 success-rate/explosive-prevention level.

Disappoints if: The OL/WR pecking order remains unstable, RB Demond Claiborne's lost RB production is not replaced, and secondary/front-seven losses turn last year's defensive strength into an ordinary unit.

Five things to remember

- 1 Quarterback:** QB Gio Lopez has been named the starter and already knows the core Rob Ezell offense from their South Alabama connection.
- 2 2025 baseline:** Wake's 2025 defense was far stronger than its offense: defensive success rate allowed ranked No.11 while offensive success rate ranked No.117.
- 3 Returning production:** Returning production is only 53% overall and 45% on offense, so the roster is much less stable than the 9-4 record suggests.
- 4 ★ DL Langston Hardy:** DL Langston Hardy is the defensive anchor after 67 tackles, 17 TFL and 7 sacks, plus Bednarik watchlist recognition.
- 5 ? Play-caller:** The exact offensive and defensive primary game-day play callers remain unresolved despite the coordinator/co-coordinator titles.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	9-4 (4-4 ACC)	● Good
Scoring	28.1 PPG	● Average / mixed
Total offense	393.8 YPG	● Average / mixed
Rush offense	156.2 YPG · 4.5 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	7.61 YPA · 18 TD / 11 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	40.2%	● Average / mixed
Scoring defense	22.1 PPG allowed	● Good / above average
Total defense	328.5 YPG allowed	● Very good
Rush defense	121.6 YPG · 3.4 YPC	● Very good
Pass defense	206.9 YPG · 5.89 YPA · 12 TD allowed	● Very good

Defense-led: total defense No.26, rush defense No.28 and pass efficiency defense No.21, while the offense sat near the national middle in scoring, yards, rushing and third downs.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-1.79 · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.055 · No. 91	● Below average
Off. success rate	37.8% · No. 117	● Poor
Off. explosive-play rate	13.2% · No. 44	● Good / above average
Havoc allowed	14.0% · No. 51	● Average / mixed
Opp.-adjusted defense	+2.05 · No. 45	● Good / above average
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.115 · No. 21	● Very good
Def. success rate allowed	35.4% · No. 11	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	8.2% · No. 10	● Elite
Havoc created	17.5% · No. 26	● Very good

Advanced-stat read: Wake's 2025 9-4 record was powered by a genuinely strong defense rather than balanced underlying efficiency. The offense was poor play-to-play despite decent explosiveness, so QB Gio Lopez/Ezell fit matters because merely preserving last year's defense may not be enough after the departures to professional football.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Jake Dickert - returning	● ↔ Program continuity supports the floor.
OC	Rob Ezell - returning	● ↑ QB Gio Lopez's direct system familiarity creates the clearest path to offensive improvement; primary caller remains unresolved.
Co-OC/QB	◆ Dan Enos - internal promotion	● ↔ Adds continuity/QB-room experience without establishing him as the primary caller.
DC	Scottie Hazelton - returning	● ↔ Returns after a strong defense; primary caller remains unresolved.
Co-DC/Safeties	◆ Freddie Banks - internal promotion	● ↔ Staff continuity helps a secondary rebuild but does not settle caller status.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Gio Lopez	North Carolina	● ↑ Named QB1 with 11 UNC starts and direct Ezell-system familiarity.
◆ OL Tolu Olajide	New Hampshire	● ↔ Brings 27 prior LT starts to a reconfigured line.
◆ C John Ohnegian	Bucknell	● ↔ Provides 35 career center starts.
◆ RB Sawyer Seidl	North Dakota	● ↔ Adds 897 rushing yards and 13 TD to the post-RB Demond Claiborne RB room.

Out	To	Loss
RB Demond Claiborne	NFL (Minnesota), Round 6, No. 198	● ↓ Lead-back loss.
QB Robby Ashford	eligibility/graduation	● ↔ 2025 starting QB departs, but QB Gio Lopez supplies a plausible replacement upgrade.
TE Eni Falayi	NFL (Green Bay), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful TE loss.
OT Fa'alili Fa'amoe	Toronto Argonauts	● ↓ Material tackle experience departs.

Offensive net: Similar ceiling but much lower continuity; wider range

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DT Sydir Mitchell	LSU	● ↔ Adds interior talent to the rotation.
◆ LB D.J. Johnson	New Hampshire	● ↔ Provides 43 tackles and rotational production.
◆ DB Bernard Causey	Georgia State	● ↔ Part of a secondary rebuild whose final alignment remains open.

Out	To	Loss
CB Karon Prunty	NFL (New England), Round 5, No. 171	● ↓ Fifth-round corner loss.
S Nick Andersen	NFL (L.A. Rams), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful safety loss.
LB Jayden Loving	NFL (Chicago), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Linebacker continuity loss.
LB Quincy Bryant	eligibility/graduation	● ↓ 57-tackle LB loss.

Defensive net: Worse than 2025, but the front retains a credible core

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Ezell structure with a quarterback who already knows the core plays/checks, supported by a broad transfer competition at RB/WR/OL.	QB Gio Lopez system familiarity and enough portal experience to raise the floor above a pure rebuild.	2025 down-to-down efficiency was poor, and several newcomer-heavy groups must settle quickly.
Defense	Aggressive, disciplined defense built around a returning disruptive front and a more volatile back seven.	DL Langston Hardy-led front, strong success-rate defense, excellent explosive prevention and above-average havoc.	Major pro departures at CB/S/LB plus unsettled secondary alignment.
Special teams	No strong positive or negative personnel identity established entering 2026.	Model baseline is near neutral.	Limited current-role clarity.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B	● ↑	Medium-high	QB Gio Lopez brings direct system familiarity to an offense that badly needs better down-to-down efficiency.
RB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	RB Ty Clark III is the front-runner to replace drafted RB Demond Claiborne.
WR	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	WR Carlos Hernandez is the top returner after 40 catches for 611 yards.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium	TE Eni Falayi is gone, leaving a less proven room without an established featured option.
OL	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	OL Tolu Olajide brings 27 prior LT starts to a rebuilt line.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↔	High	DL Langston Hardy returns after 67 tackles, 17 TFL and 7 sacks to anchor the defense.
LB	● B–	● ↓	Medium	LB Aiden Hall’s 73 tackles and 8 TFL make him the main returning second-level leader.
Secondary	● C+	● ↓	Low	DB Davaughn Patterson is a returning piece in a secondary replacing multiple pros and still sorting alignment.
Special teams	● C+	● ↔	Low	Model baseline is near neutral.
Coaching	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	Staff continuity and internal promotions support the floor while game-day caller roles remain unresolved.
Overall	● B–	● ↓	Medium-low	Bowl-line Power 4 team with a defense-first floor and a wide offensive range

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through August 24, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
◆ Gio Lopez (TR: North Carolina)	QB	● Named Power 4 starter with strong system fit	-	Formally named QB1 and remains the clearest route to fixing a 2025 offense that ranked No.91 in EPA/play and No.117 in success rate.
Langston Hardy	DL	● High-end conference defender	Bednarik Award	Returns after 67 tackles, 17 TFL and 7 sacks and anchors the most trustworthy unit.
Aiden Hall	LB	● High-end conference starter	-	73 tackles and 8 TFL make him the main returning second-level leader.
Carlos Hernandez	WR	● Solid Power 4 starter	-	Top returning receiver after 40 catches for 611 yards.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Ty Clark III	RB	● Power 4 lead-back projection	-	Front-runner to replace drafted Demond Claiborne.
◆ Tolu Olajide (TR: New Hampshire)	OL	● Experienced tackle projection	-	Twenty-seven prior LT starts are stabilizing experience for a rebuilt line.
◆ John Ohnegian (TR: Bucknell)	C	● Experienced center projection	-	Thirty-five career starts give the new line an experienced organizing point.
Davaughn Patterson	DB	● Returning secondary core candidate	-	One of the few meaningful returning back-end pieces in a secondary replacing multiple pros; exact alignment remains open.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	● Moderate but unforgiving for a bowl-line team; there are enough toss-up games to reach six wins, but also clear top-end losses and a difficult midseason run.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 56
Hardest stretch	Miami → at Louisville → Stanford → at NC State → at California
Swing games	at Purdue, Stanford, at NC State, at California, Virginia, at Georgia Tech, Duke
Advantage	Akron and Merrimack provide two home nonconference opportunities, and the bye precedes the Virginia/Merrimack segment.
Expected	6.1 wins · likely 6-6
Floor / ceiling	4-8 / 8-4

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	The 9-4 record may create residual optimism, but SP+ No.57, ACC media No.13 and low offensive returning production argue for treating Wake as a bowl-line team rather than a proven upper-half ACC side.
Back them when	As an underdog or short favorite against mediocre offenses if DL Langston Hardy's front is intact and QB Gio Lopez improves early-down efficiency.
Fade/pass when	Against strong passing teams before the secondary alignment is proven, or when asked to lay points while the OL/WR rotation remains unsettled.
Key monitor	Final OL five, WR pecking order, Secondary alignment, Primary offensive/defensive callers, RB workload split, Late camp availability
Week 1 baseline	Wake Forest -28.5 vs. Akron · early rating-based fair value; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Wake Forest -23.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Wake Forest's defense remains the more trustworthy side behind DL Langston Hardy, while QB Gio Lopez's familiarity with OC Rob Ezell gives the rebuilt offense a plausible path to better efficiency. The portal-heavy RB, WR and OL groups still have to settle.

That combination keeps Wake near bowl eligibility rather than near last year's nine wins. Six wins is the sound center, with upside if QB/system fit translates quickly and the rebuilt secondary preserves the defense's 2025 strengths.

About this primer

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Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching staff](#) · [QB Lopez](#) · [OC Ezell](#) · [DC Hazelton](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [QB preview](#) · [OL preview](#) · [QB1 update](#)

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